

De-escalation likely as US leans toward temporary fix to open strait

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【メール原文】

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De-escalation in the Middle East is now likely (60%, up from 25%), as the space for the US to escalate its bombing campaign shrinks.

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The US and Iran are likely to reach a temporary accommodation that includes joint Iran-Oman management of the Strait of Hormuz and an end to the US blockade.

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The arrangement will be unsteady, as the US will resist making additional concessions and Iran will push maximalist demands, suggesting an elevated risk of another flare-up that closes the strait by year's end.

De-escalation is now the basecase. The US decision to hold off on large-scale strikes and momentum on an interim deal to open the Strait of Hormuz suggests de-escalation is likely (60%, up from 25%). While US escalation remains a serious possibility (30%, down from 55%), the space for President Donald Trump to expand military action has shrunk considerably.

Trump pulled back from strikes twice in recent weeks due to last-minute pressure from those opposed to escalation, and the latest deal framework still lacks his blessing. Trump's advisers and negotiators have a long history of lobbying him through the media, and his own preferences remain unclear.

If Trump signs off, the US will opt for a temporary fix that opens the strait. Reopening the strait by force alone was never a realistic goal; US escalation plans were more about lowering Iran's negotiating threshold (see: [Iran war escalation & energy implications](#) , 29 July 2026). Assuming Trump approves, Washington is now moving toward a temporary deal that prioritizes reopening of the strait—even if it includes a more permanent role for Iran in managing the waterway.

The current round of talks may not produce an agreement; there have been many false starts over the last six months. However, the constraints on US action, the limited appetite for a destructive round of escalation, and regional pressure to prioritize diplomacy suggest an interim arrangement that reopens the strait is likely in the coming weeks.

De-escalation will include compromise on joint Iran-Oman management of the strait. As Iran and Oman share the Strait of Hormuz, any new arrangement that entrenches Tehran's influence will have to incorporate Oman, with buy-in from the rest of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC). The current

proposal is an interim deal, where ships enter the Gulf via Iran's northern route and exit via Oman's southern route. Tehran has insisted that all ships transiting the strait coordinate with Iranian authorities.

Oman (along with the rest of the GCC, the US, and most of the international community) will continue to reject per-ship tolls, which violate international law and are unacceptable to insurers. Instead, Oman is pushing for voluntary fees collected from both regional states and shipping companies to cover the cost of managing the strait. Iran is likely to accept this on an interim basis, though it is unlikely to fully abandon its demand on tolls.

Iran will require US to lift blockade before opening the strait. Confident the US is deterred from escalating, Tehran will likely press for more concessions—a return to the June deal, resumed oil sanctions waivers, and release of frozen funds. These will not come easily: unfreezing funds is technically complex, and any deal eliminating prior sanctions triggers a 30-to-60-day Congressional review. Iran will likely need to settle for an interim deal confirming its control of the strait and ending the blockade, though it will push for further concessions in subsequent negotiations.

A shaky truce, rather than a durable peace, will be the new status quo. Even if the US, Iran, Oman and others reach an interim deal to reopen the strait, uncertainty over remaining issues—particularly fees for service—and the limited space for further diplomatic progress means the new peace will be very tenuous.

The US and Iran are unlikely to rapidly return to their June accord. Scope for progress on the nuclear issue will remain limited, even if direct US-Iran talks resume in the coming months. Iran's leadership will continue to tolerate risk, seeing upside in using aggressive tactics against regional neighbors and in the strait. This suggests an acute risk of another flare-up leading to renewed hostilities and a third closure of the strait before the end of the year.

Hormuz traffic will recover slowly. Even with de-escalation and an Iran-Oman understanding that reopens the strait, many shippers will be hesitant given lingering risks from Iranian mines in the central waterway. With the US and Iran likely to remain at odds, the risk of another round of fighting that closes the strait will stay acute.

As a result, while traffic will recover under a de-escalation scenario, it is unlikely to exceed 30%-50% of prewar traffic before the end of 2026. Pressure to rapidly resume traffic through the strait is likely to gradually diminish as regional actors build out alternative routes for commodities and particularly crude oil (See: Strait of Hormuz significance for oil trade could be cut in half by 2030 , 22 July 2026).

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